The governing question: should this firm move to a four-day week — 100% pay, 80% of the time, 100% of the output?

# Yes — as a bounded pilot in two practice groups, not as a firm-wide commitment

**89%**
of the 61 UK pilot companies were still on reduced hours after twelve months

**0**
business metrics reached statistical significance, on the pilot's own account

**1 of 1**
professional-services firms in the follow-up stopped — over client expectations

✔ **The wellbeing effect is large, controlled and replicated.**
Burnout fell from 2.8 to 2.34 and stress from 3.07 to 2.74 across the UK cohort, and a controlled six-country study of nearly 2,900 workers in 141 organisations found the same gains absent in its controls.

– **The business case is unproven, not disproven.**
Revenue rose 1.4% from trial start to end and resignations fell from 2.0 to 0.8 per 100 employees — but the pilot's own report states that these trends cannot be called statistically significant.

✘ **Professional services is the observed failure mode.**
The single organisation of 28 that discontinued at twelve months was a consultancy, and it stopped over client and stakeholder expectations despite reporting morale, wellbeing and efficiency benefits.

**The gap that stops this being stronger:**
the UK cohort was overwhelmingly tiny employers — 37% had 1–10 staff and only 10% were above 100 people — and no large UK professional-services firm with published results was found.

Client scope: a 200-person UK professional-services firm, illustrative and unnamed. Every firm-specific figure in this memo is labelled illustrative; every external figure carries its source, period and basis.

# Every pilot promised eight hours back and delivered four to five

The decision is about recoverable hours, not about a day of the week.

**SITUATION**

100-80-100, defined by 4 Day Week Global in 2018. UK hours and productivity: ONS.

F064 · F068 · F069

100-80-100 means 100% pay for 80% of the time while maintaining 100% output. It was created in 2018 by Andrew Barnes and Charlotte Lockhart at Perpetual Guardian, and 4 Day Week Global defines it as a 32-hour week rather than compressed hours.

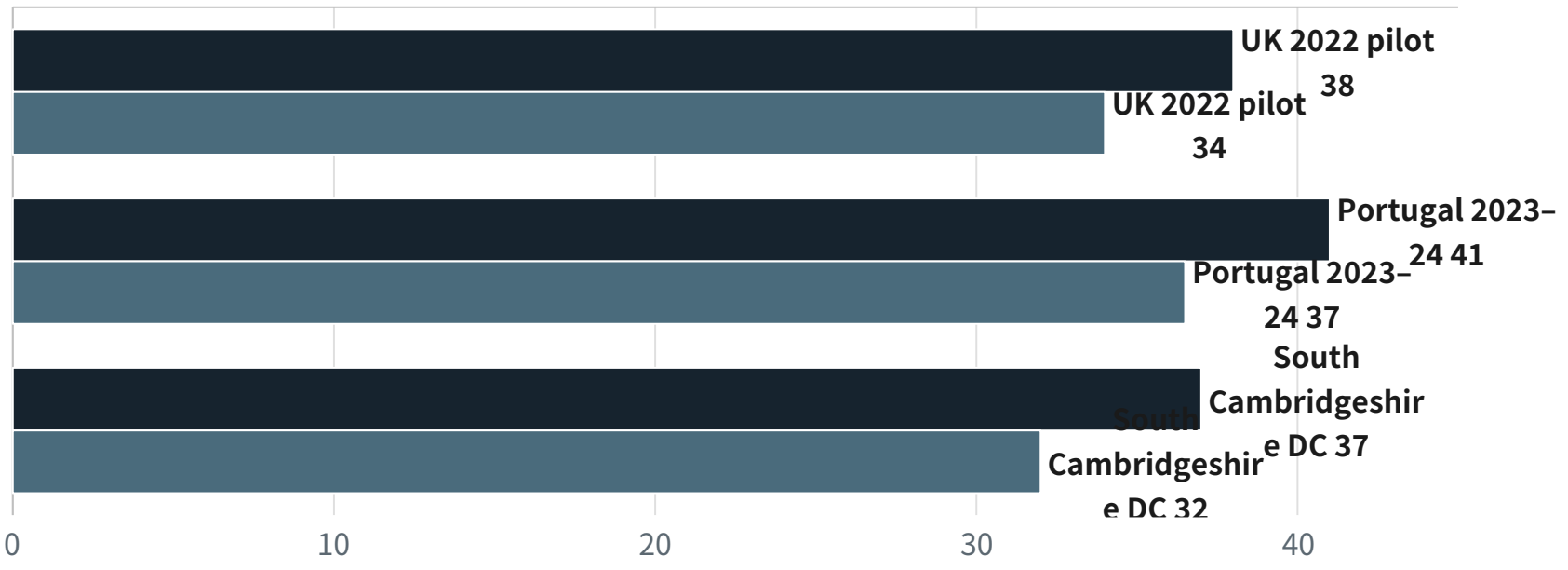
Against the UK norm the cut is smaller than it sounds. Average actual weekly hours for UK full-time workers were 36.7 in April–June 2026, so a 32-hour week is about a 13% reduction, not 20% — while UK output per hour, at £46.92 in 2021, was already 10% below the average of the other G7 nations excluding Japan.

**COMPLICATION**

Nominal target against hours actually worked, by study.

F011 · F040 · F054 · F063

In every measured pilot the realised reduction was smaller than the nominal one. Across the UK cohort, 71% of employees reported fewer hours — and 15% reported working more.




**RESOLUTION**

The question this memo answers.

So the question is not “should we adopt a four-day week”. It is: how many hours can this firm recover through redesign, and what does removing the rest cost in client service?

# Three of the four drivers are ours; the one that stopped a consultancy is not

Whether 100-80-100 holds here is decided by four conditions, and only one of them sits outside our control.

Governing question: how many hours can this firm recover through redesign, and what does removing the rest cost in client service?

WITHIN OUR CONTROL

## 1 Recoverable hours

F021 · F050

The pilots’ main levers were shorter and fewer meetings with clearer agendas, email-etiquette reform, protected focus periods and automated reporting. Germany’s participants named meeting culture and reduced distraction as their main efficiency levers.

## 2 Redesign effort

F045

Only 8% of Portuguese companies that made two or more organisational changes reverted to five days, against 38% of those that made none or one. Three-quarters made at least one change, and 87% reported active worker participation in redesigning processes.

## 3 Retention economics

F008 · F065 · F070

Resignations fell from 2.0 to 0.8 per 100 employees in the UK pilot, and Awin reports regrettable turnover down 33%. The most-cited UK replacement cost, £30,614, is a 2014 figure and is not inflation-adjusted, so any saving from it is illustrative arithmetic.

## 4 Client tolerance

⚠ EXTERNAL — NOT OURS TO DECIDE

F028 · F037

The cohort’s only twelve-month discontinuation was a small consultancy that stopped over client and stakeholder expectations. Belgium’s reduced-hours pilot drew one fully participating company, citing sectoral expectation.

Three drivers respond to preparation; this one responds only to client evidence.

# The wellbeing result is established; the business result is unproven

Nothing in the public record establishes that revenue or retention improves.

**ESTABLISHED**

Controlled, replicated, peer-reviewed.

F050 · F062

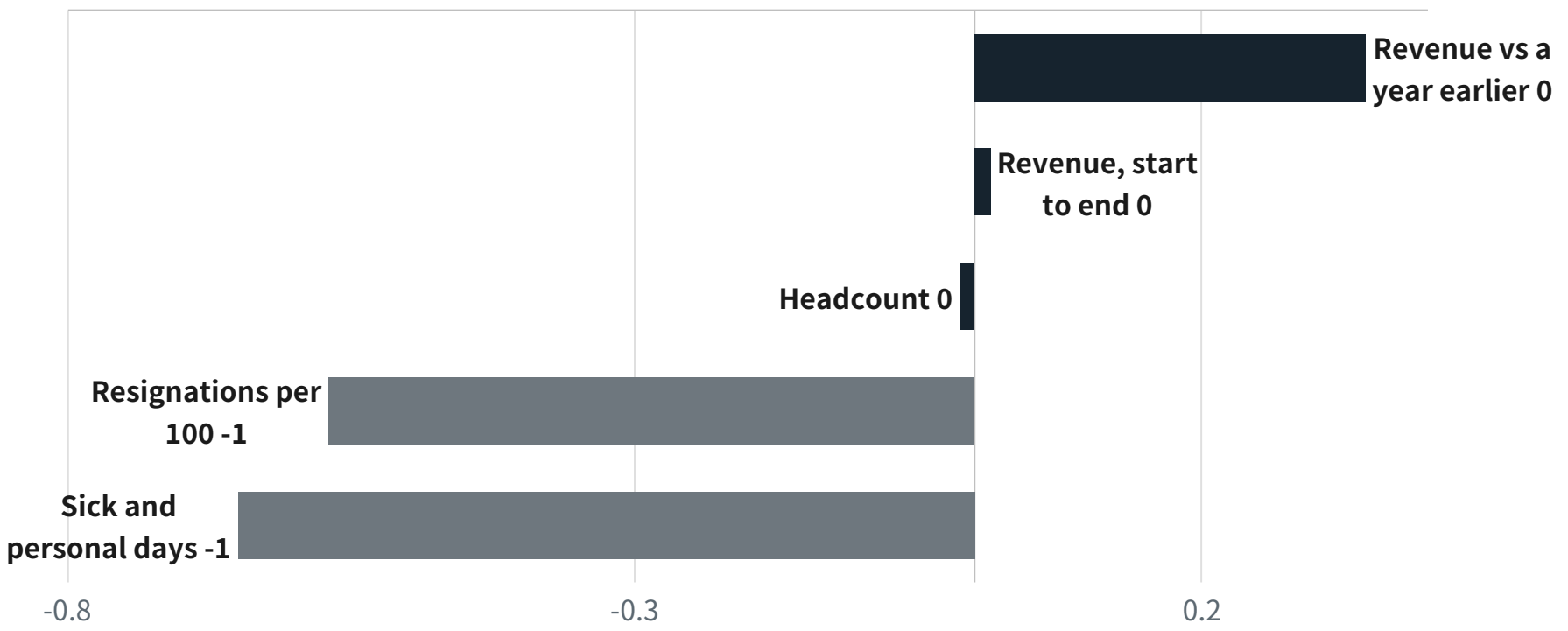
**NOT ESTABLISHED**

Stated by the reporting authors themselves.

F010 · F051 · F052

A controlled study of nearly 2,900 workers across 141 organisations in six countries found gains in burnout, job satisfaction and mental and physical health that were absent in its controls. Germany’s instrumented pilot found the same falls in stress and burnout against its own control groups.

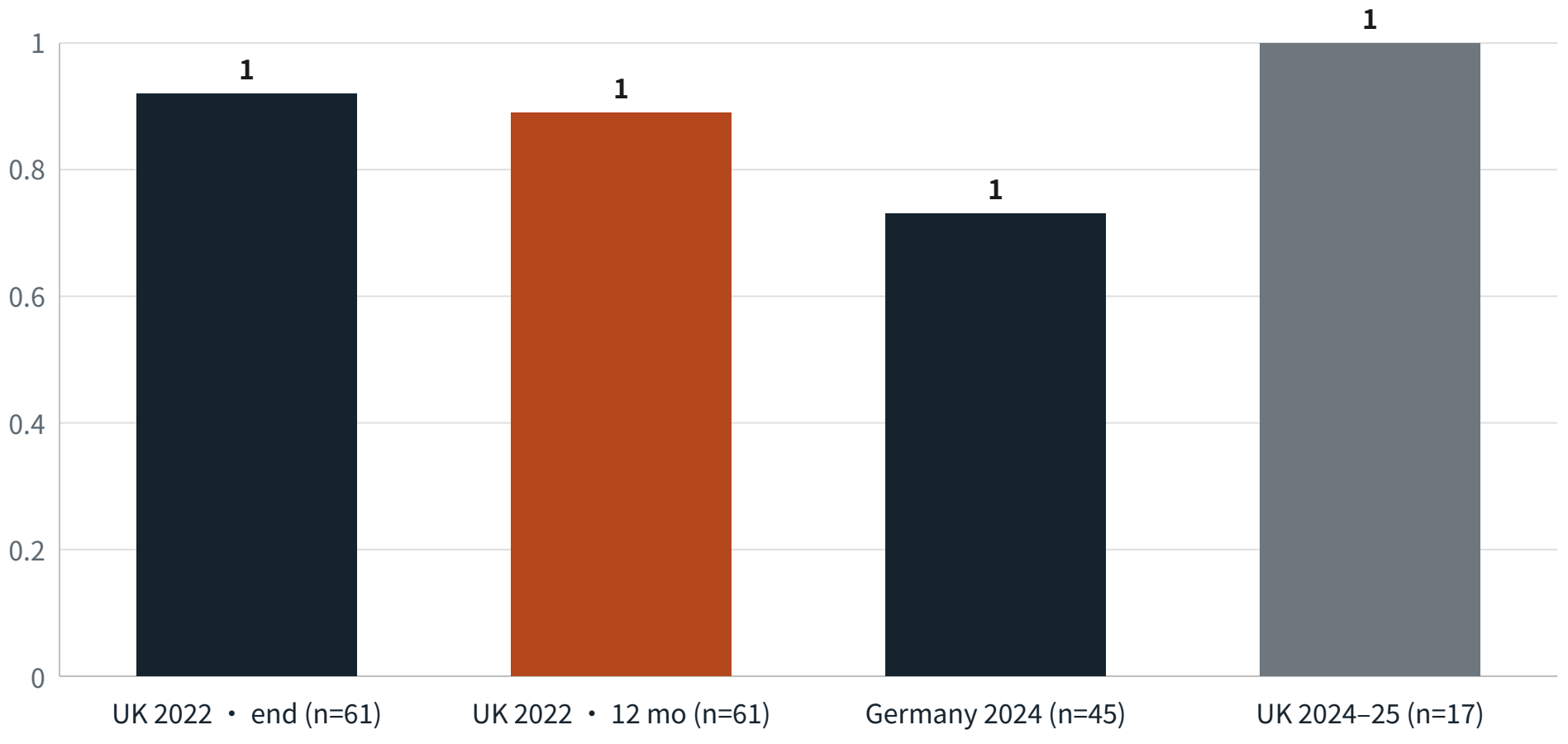
The UK 2022 report states that its resignation, new-hire and absence trends cannot be called statistically significant, given small sample numbers and labour-market contingencies. Germany found sick days, turnover and profit changed only slightly and not significantly.




> Every revenue figure here is self-reported by the participating firm — an assumption, not a finding. The standing pattern is documented in the primary reports rather than asserted by critics: participation is self-selected by management; control arms are absent, small or non-random; and follow-up samples shrink, with 28 of 61 organisations at twelve months.
>
> **This evidence can justify a controlled trial. It cannot justify a commitment.**

# Persistence is high everywhere — and highest where the base is smallest

The continuation rates are real, but they measure self-selected cohorts and they are not entitlements.




**NOT AN ENTITLEMENT**

UK twelve-month follow-up, 28 organisations.

F025

**BASE SIZE**

Continuation rates against their cohort size.

F029 · F071

Of the 28 organisations in the twelve-month follow-up, 39% were permanent with updated terms and conditions and 39% were permanent without changing contracts — an opt-in policy the employer can withdraw at will.

A 100% continuation rate on 17 self-selected companies is a weaker signal than 89% on 61, and this memo does not lead with it. Universal or staggered day-off models converted to permanence in 95% of cases against 60% for flexible ones — on a sample the authors call too small for significance.

# Only two of these seven studies are evidence about a firm like ours

On a common basis, most of the precedents we are quoted are about a different intervention or a different sector.

| Study | What changed, and what it found | Scale, period, control | Evidence about a firm like ours? |
|---|---|---|---|
| UK 2022 pilot | Real hours cut at full pay; 92% still running it at the end | 61 companies · Jun–Dec 2022 · no control | Yes, with a scale caveat |
| UK follow-up 2024 | 89% still on reduced hours a year on; the one firm that stopped was a consultancy | 28 of 61 · 2024 · no control | Yes — the closest case we have |
| Iceland 2015–19 | 40 hours to 35–36 and service levels held. Veal: 61 of 66 sites cut only one to three hours | ~2,940 workers · 2015–2019 · no control | No — public sector, a 1–3 hour cut |
| Belgium 2022 | A right to compress 38 hours into four days; hours and pay unchanged | National law · from Nov 2022 | No — not an hours reduction |
| Portugal 2023–24 | Actual hours down 12%, 41+ to 36.5; the authors call it a proof of concept | 41 companies · from Jun 2023 · non-adopter control | Partly — best design, other sectors |
| Germany 2024 | Stress and burnout down significantly; sick days, turnover and profit not | 45 orgs · 6 months from Feb 2024 · in-house control | Partly — best method, mixed model |
| South Cambridgeshire | 32 hours at full pay; 11 outcomes better, 2 worse, the rest indistinguishable | One council · from Jan 2023 · COVID-adjusted | No — statutory public services |

Dark: evidence about a firm like ours. Slate: partly relevant. Grey: a different intervention or a different sector.

**Recorded conflict — Iceland.**
The same trials are read as a transformative national success and as a one-to-three-hour cut whose national legacy is 35 minutes a week.

**Recorded conflict — South Cambridgeshire.**
The council reports 21 of 24 services improved or stayed the same and a saving of nearly £400,000 a year; the independent evaluation reports 11 outcomes better, 2 worse and the rest indistinguishable, and cannot prove causation.

# Pilot 100-80-100 in two practice groups, after ten weeks of redesign

Two whole practice groups, about 60 people (illustrative scope), on 100% pay and a universal day off with a target 32-hour week. Ten weeks of redesign first, six months of operation, one interim gate, and no change to contracts for the duration.

| Weeks 1–10 · Redesign | Months 1–6 · Operate at 100-80-100 |
|---|---|

The pilot is bounded in time and reversible at its interim gate.

**Redesign before, not during.**
8% of Portuguese companies reverted after two or more organisational changes, against 38% after none or one. Two to three months of preparation is the norm.

**A universal day off, not a flexible model.**
Universal or staggered models converted to permanence in 95% of cases against 60% for flexible ones, on a sample the authors call too small for significance.

**Measure before you promise.**
Half the Portuguese companies could not define productivity metrics at all, so the metric set is agreed in redesign and published before the pilot starts.

**No entitlement.**
Nearly half the permanent cases in the UK follow-up never changed contracts. This pilot is stated as non-contractual in writing.

- Kill criteria, agreed before the start and reviewed at the interim gate: client satisfaction, on-time delivery, realisation, utilisation, voluntary attrition.

Scenario data — thresholds are the firm's to set and are illustrative here.

> **Not recommended, and why:**
> a firm-wide permanent commitment, which has no evidence at this scale or sector; a compressed four-day week, which keeps total hours; and an hours cut spread across five days, which drifts from the intervention tested.

# Two gates, and the firm can stop at either one

The pilot is reversible by design, and the points of reversal are fixed before it starts.




**Phase 0**
**Redesign**
Weeks 1–10 · COO

Cut meeting length and frequency and reform email etiquette — the pilots' most common changes. Agree the metric set and the client communication plan.

**Phase 1**
**Operate**
Months 1–6 · Practice heads

Two practice groups, a universal day off, contractual position unchanged.

**Gate A**
**Interim read**
Month 3 · Executive committee

Are the kill criteria holding? Most Portuguese indicators slipped between three and six months for reasons the authors could not fully explain, so month 3 is the high-water mark, not the trend.

**Phase 2**
**Evaluate**
Month 7 · Finance director

Compare against the non-participating practice groups as a control — the design Portugal used and the UK 2022 pilot lacked.

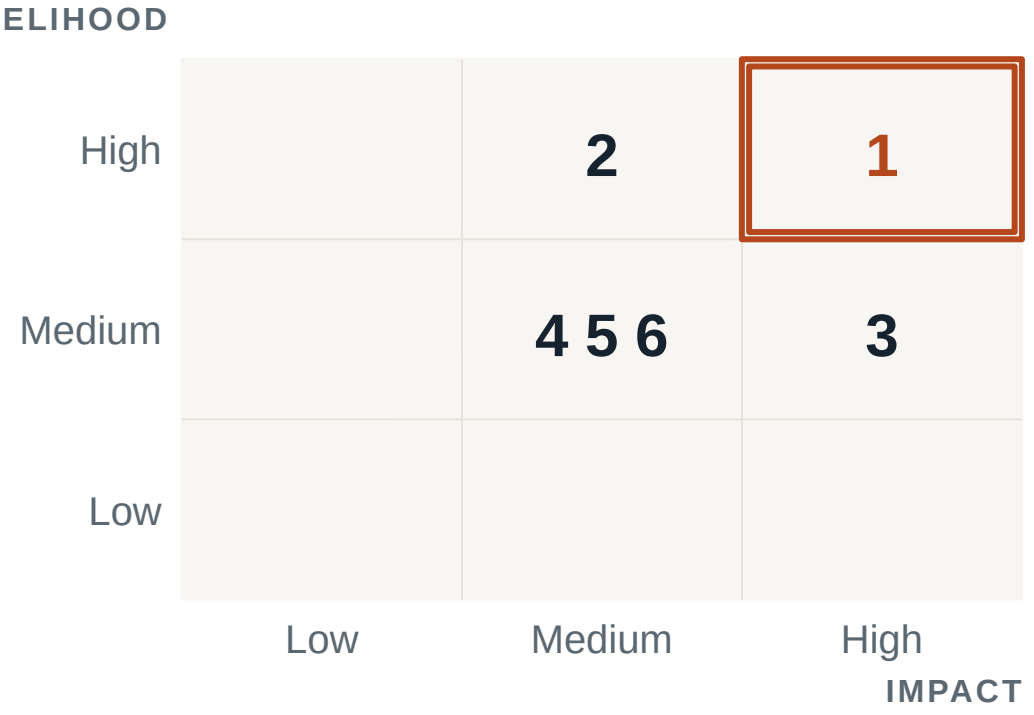
**Gate B**
**Decide**
Month 8 · Executive committee

Extend, adjust, or stop. A decision to extend is a decision to reopen contracts.

Scenario data — owners, dates and phase lengths are illustrative and are the firm's to set.

# The risk that stopped the only comparable firm is the one we cannot mitigate away

Client expectation is the binding risk; everything else is a preparation problem.




Risk 1 sits alone in the top-right cell. It is the only risk here that preparation cannot remove, because it depends on how clients react — and it is what stopped the one comparable firm.

| # | Risk | Likelihood | Impact | Mitigation | Owner |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Client and stakeholder expectations (F028 · F037) | High | High | Client communication agreed in Phase 0; stated response times unchanged | Practice heads |
| 2 | Hours creep: a nominal 32-hour week worked as 34–36 (F011 · F040) | High | Medium | Measure actual hours, not the policy; treat creep as a kill-criterion input | COO |
| 3 | No agreed definition of productivity (F047) | Medium | High | Metrics fixed in Phase 0 and published before the pilot starts | Finance director |
| 4 | Benefit fade after month 3 (F043) | Medium | Medium | Gate A is the high-water mark; the six-month read decides | HR director |
| 5 | Entitlement dispute on withdrawal (F025) | Medium | Medium | Non-contractual status stated in writing and acknowledged by each participant | HR director |
| 6 | Inequitable application across a small team (F028) | Medium | Medium | Whole-practice-group scope rather than individual opt-in | Practice heads |

Likelihood and impact ratings are the firm’s judgement, not findings — scenario data. The risks themselves are sourced; the ratings are not. Accent marks a High rating, slate a Medium one.

External note: a Best Value Notice was issued to South Cambridgeshire District Council in November 2023, reissued in May 2024 and allowed to expire in November 2024, alongside a statement that it is not government policy to support a general move to a four-day week for five days’ pay. Relevant to a private firm only as a signal about external legitimacy.

# Every figure above is one link from its primary source

## Where credible sources disagree, this memo names the disagreement rather than reconciling it.

Standing limitations that apply to every study below: management self-selects participation; company financial data is self-reported; control arms are absent, small or non-random; and follow-up samples shrink.

Definitions: 100-80-100 is 100% pay for 80% of the time at 100% output, as defined by 4 Day Week Global. “Continuation” means still operating the policy, which is not the same as a contractual entitlement. “Not statistically significant” is the reporting authors’ own wording.

Deliberately not claimed: any figure for this firm; any productivity forecast; any saving derived from the 2014 replacement-cost figure as anything other than illustrative arithmetic. The named company accounts (Awin, Atom bank) are self-published, not independent evaluations.

Autonomy, February 2023 · pages 1–6

Autonomy, February 2024 · pages 1, 5, 6, 7, 9

Autonomy and Alda, July 2021 · page 6

Anthony Veal, The Conversation, 2021 · page 6

L&E Global, November 2022 · page 6

KPMG Law Belgium · page 6

The Brussels Times · pages 3, 6

Gomes and Fontinha, July 2024 · pages 2–9

Birkbeck, University of London · page 6

University of Münster, 2024 · pages 4, 5, 6

The Local, November 2024 · pages 4, 5

Cambridge democracy portal, March 2024 · pages 2, 6

Salford and Cambridge, via scambs.gov.uk · page 6

LocalGov, July 2025 · page 6

scambs.gov.uk, November 2024 · page 9

Fraser of Allander, Economics Observatory · page 4

Nature Human Behaviour 9, 2025 · pages 1, 4

Nature news, 2025 · pages 2, 4

4 Day Week Global · pages 2, 7

Awin, February 2023 · page 3 · self-published

Atom bank, October 2022 · page 10 · self-published

Canadian Lawyer · page 10

ONS, April–June 2026 · page 2

ONS, 2021 final estimates · page 2

Oxford Economics for Unum, February 2014 · page 3

4 Day Week Foundation · page 5

The Big Issue · page 5